Fawcett, an enthusiastic amateur antiquarian. Fawcett got in touch with his old friend Bruce Foote, who was far more interested in the petroglyphs and stone tools that Fawcett had also found at the site. However, he sent Fawcett's rubbings of the inscriptions to the Government Epigraphist in Madras, Dr Eugen Hultzsch, who declared four of them to be written in what appeared to be defective Brahmi and the remaining two 'decidedly archaic' but unreadable. More than seventy years passed before these copies were re-examined, by which time the originals had been obliterated under modern graffiti.

Such cave inscriptions only began to be taken seriously in 1906, after the Deputy Collector of Tirunelveli reported the existence of an inscription in a rock-shelter on a hill above the village of Marukaltalai, 15 kilometres west of Tirunelveli. Two more rock-shelters with inscriptions were then discovered in quick succession near Madurai, leading to a scramble that resulted in the discovery of no fewer than thirty-nine new inscriptions from twelve sites all within easy reach of Madurai – in fact, wherever there were rocky outcrops with caves or rock-shelters.

Several trained archaeologists and epigraphists now became directly involved, including Valaiyattur Venkayya, head of the Epigraphical Department of the Government of Madras, and his assistant, K. V. Subrahmanya Aiyer (also written Iyer).[21] The outcome was the publication in 1924 of Subrahmanya Aiyer's justly celebrated paper 'The earliest monuments of the Pandya country and their inscriptions', in which he proposed for the first time that these inscriptions were not only written in a Tamil version of Ashokan Brahmi script but also employed the Tamil language itself rather than Prakrit.

But if U. V. Swaminatha Iyer and K. V. Subrahmanya Aiyer laid the foundations of Tamil philology and Tamil-Brahmi epigraphy respectively, it was left to an outstanding scholar